Cultural assumptions and bias in assessment

Have I checked cultural assumptions and hidden norms?

WHAT IS IT?

Cultural assumptions and hidden norms about expression are identified and removed where irrelevant to outcomes

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

Teaching is never neutral. Choices about readings, cases, examples, guest speakers, classroom norms and professional pathways tell students whose lives and knowledge are considered normal, legitimate or peripheral. When students cannot recognise themselves or their communities in the discipline, participation can start to feel risky or pointless.

THE STUDENT EXPERIENCE

- “People like me do not seem to exist in this field.”
- “We only appear when the course is discussing disadvantage or a problem.”

HOW CAN I DO IT?

- Check whether the task rewards one style of expression when that style is not the learning outcome.
- Clarify which conventions are essential and which are inherited habits.
- Rewrite criteria so they assess the capability you genuinely care about.

EXAMPLE IN PRACTICE

A rubric removes vague references to “professional tone” and instead specifies audience awareness, clarity and appropriate evidence use.

STARTING POINT TO ADAPT

For this assessment, we aim to check whether assessment rewards cultural assumptions or communication norms that are not part of the intended learning outcome. The learning outcomes being assessed are [insert outcomes].

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Designing assessment

Creating and using rubrics